Union health ministry, India faces an annual demand for 175,000 kidney, 50,000 liver, heart and lung and 2,500 pancreas transplants. However, despite advancements in medical science, the supply of donated organs is heartbreakingly low. The Organ Receiving & Giving Awareness Network of India, a Delhi-based NGO, estimates the number of patients waiting for a transplant to be as high as 500,000.

In the countrywide wait list with the National Organ & Tissue Transplant Organization (NOTTO), updated till September 2024, 57,806 patients have been listed for kidney transplants, while only 13,426 such transplants were performed in 2023. Similarly, 19,847 are listed for liver, as against 4,491 liver transplants; 2,671 for heart transplants, as against 221 surgeries. The wait list is 1,771 for lungs, while the number of lung transplants was 197; 277 people had enlisted for pancreas transplants while only 27 got them. And while small intestine transplantation had a wait list of 92, only 16 small intestine transplants were performed in 2023. In all, 18,336 persons received 18,378 donated organs.

Sadly, India's organ donation rate is less than one per million population (PMP), according to a 2024 report from the National Academy of Medical Sciences, New Delhi. To achieve self-sufficiency, the required rate is around 124 PMP. "Many patients rely on dialysis for years, either waiting for a donor or financial support for a transplant. Many die due to lack of medical services that are affordable or accessible," says Dr Neeraj Saraf, senior director, liver transplant, Medanta, in Gurugram. The main reasons for the abysmally low number of organ donations in India are lack of awareness, fear of disfigurement (in case of live organ donation), religious reasons and lack of faith in the healthcare system.

THE CRY FOR ORGANS

The three organs most in demand remain the kidney, liver and heart. "Kidney transplants top the list due to the high prevalence of chronic kidney disease and diabetes," explains Dr Swapnil Sharma, consultant, HPB and liver transplant, at Wockhardt Hospitals in Mumbai. "Similarly, liver transplants are sought-after due to alcohol-related liver diseases, hepatitis infections and fatty liver conditions. Heart and lung transplants are also needed for patients suffering from end-stage heart failure and chronic respiratory diseases caused by air pollution—a growing concern," he adds.



DR NEERAJ SARAF
Senior Director, Liver Transplant, Medanta, Gurugram

"Many patients rely on dialysis for their entire lives, either waiting for a donor or financial support. Many default on treatment...or die due to lack of affordable/ accessible medical services"

Yet families of patients are often left to despair for want of a donated organ. Samira Bhatt's father was one such patient. "It was the worst phase of my life," says the 39-year-old homemaker from Delhi. She checked the NOTTO website every morning to see if an organ was available for her father who had been diagnosed with end-stage liver disease. "Despite the urgency, which I was told means you are prioritised for an organ, we never got one and he passed away," she adds. While the urgency of transplants influence wait time, so do blood type compatibility, organ size and proximity to the hospital where the organ was donated.

Aakash Kumar, 41, an investment banker from Mumbai who lost his mother after a car accident severely injured her kidneys and heart, says, "At the hospital, a man approached us and said he could procure the organs at a high price. We agreed. But before the deal could be made, she passed away," he says. However, for recipients, a new organ is a fresh lease of life. "I had chronic type 2 diabetes...till age 65, I had such poor vision that they predicted blindness in a few years. Last year, at age 66...a kind friend who lost her father agreed for the cornea donation and I received it. It is difficult to describe the feeling...that my eyes are not my own. But I am tremendously grateful," says Kamla Mangawa, 67, a retired banking executive from Pune.

LIVE VS DECEASED DONORS

Significantly, most organ donations in India happen through live donors. For example, out of the 13,426 kidney transplants in India in 2023, 10,896 were from living donors. This trend, say experts, applies to all organs, and is a reason behind such a huge gap between demand and supply.

According to a process regulated by the Transplantation of Human Organs Act 1994 (THOA), to qualify as a living donor, a person must be 18-55 years old, with a blood group matching that of the patient, be a close relative, have a healthy organ, and not suffer from serious illnesses. But a living donor can only donate one kidney, 40 per cent of the liver (the organ can regenerate) and bone marrow. For other organs, one has to depend on deceased donors. For live donations, the donor pool is also restricted to close relatives. Post-mortem donations depend on the donor being declared brain-dead—the usual condition for deceased organ donation, where there is cessation of brain and brain stem activity, but the heart beats still, and there is circulation of blood to organs, making them viable for retrieval.